Key question
Why did Syria leave the UAR in 1961?

The end of the UAR 1961

In 1958 Arab nationalism reached the height of its power. But from now onwards, it entered a period of gradual decline. First, the new Iraqi government put its own interests first and decided not to join the UAR. Secondly, the euphoria that had greeted the formation of the UAR soon turned to disillusionment in Syria. There were many reasons, mostly to do with Syrians being made to feel inferior. As expected, the army and the government of the new Arab state were dominated by Egyptians but landowners and businessmen became resentful too. They disliked Nasser's 'Arab socialism' (see the box below). The Egyptians insisted that Syria carry out land reform, breaking up the big estates and redistributing land to the peasants, as had been done in Egypt. Then the major industries and the banks in Syria were taken over by the government. What may have worked in Egypt did not go down well in Syria. The urban masses may have remained loyal to the UAR but the élites became disaffected. In September 1961 Syrian army officers carried out a **coup** against those 'who have humiliated Syria and degraded her army'. Egyptian forces did not intervene and the new Syrian Prime Minister said he wanted to maintain a close alliance with Egypt: there was still huge support among Syrians for the idea of Arab unity. But Nasser's prestige and his status as the unifying symbol of Arab nationalism were dented.

Key date
Syria left the UAR: 1961

Key term
Coup
Sudden or violent change of government.

Nasser's 'Arab socialism'

After coming to power, Nasser had set out to transform the Egyptian economy and share the country's wealth more fairly. He started with land reform. In the early 1950s, a small number of landowners owned a third of the cultivated land in Egypt while 72 per cent of the rural population owned an acre or less. Nasser's government passed a law which limited land owning to 200 acres per person, later reduced to 100 acres. The land confiscated from those who owned more than this amount was then redistributed amongst the poorer farmers.

Later, in 1961, the government nationalised the export of cotton, Egypt's main product, and took over the banks and many large industrial companies. They also confiscated the property of over a thousand of the wealthiest landowners. This huge programme, accompanied by an expansion in schools and hospitals, was intended to reduce poverty and increase opportunities for the masses. By the mid-1960s most Egyptians were considerably better off, certainly healthier and better fed, than they had been when Nasser came to power. They had also regained pride and dignity after years of foreign domination.

Yemen 1962

In 1962 a group of pro-Egyptian army officers seized power in the small, poor Arab state of Yemen, which borders Saudi Arabia (see the map on page 1). The son of the deposed monarch